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Library Column: Library staff suggests hot weather reads

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Summer is here again in full swing. Whether you're on vacation or just hanging around town, summer is a great time to read, so this week we thought we'd just offer a list of staff recommendations for good books.

I'll start off with my own:

"Thomas Jefferson: The Art of Power" by John Meacham. This book is a couple of years old, and it was on all of the bestseller lists when it came out, but I just finally had the time to read it this summer. I actually read the last chapter on the morning of July 4 - the 188th anniversary of Jefferson's death. Many people might find its size daunting (800 pages) but, at a time when our political system seems to be stalled over philosophical issues, it was good to read about Jefferson's ability to focus on the practical aspects of moving the country forward, even if that forward momentum meant compromising on some of his philosophical beliefs during his time as governor of Virginia, secretary of state, vice president and finally as president.

I also recommend Harlow Giles Unger's "John Quincy Adams" (also a couple of years old) because Adams had many of the same problems during his presidency we're having now with political gridlock, but, unlike Jefferson, J.Q. Adams never found practical ways to work with the other branches of government during his time as president.

Our youth services manager, Jacki, recommends several books. An adult title, "Everything I Never Told You" by Celeste Ng, is heartbreaking but ultimately hopeful. The story unravels the mysterious drowning of a family's favorite child (murder? suicide?) by examining the quiet, everyday thoughts and secrets her parents kept from each other. Super sad, but super good, says Jacki.

Another is "Landline" by Rainbow Rowell, also for adult readers. Rowell starts with a quirky premise - a woman discovers she can speak to a past version of her husband using a landline telephone - and adds plenty of meditation on modern relationships for a funny but surprisingly thoughtful read. We still have a landline phone in our house, and it might be nice to learn some ways to put it to new uses.

For younger readers Jacki recommends "The Boundless" by Kenneth Oppel, which is about circuses, Sasquatches and villains all traveling the transcontinental railroad.

Also for younger readers, Elaine, one of our circulation desk employees, recommends "Fairy Garden Handbook," which she has been reading with her daughter, Ayda. Ayda adores the little fairy gardens she saw at the library and Renaissance Fair this year, and this book is a great supplemental resource.

For older readers Elaine recommends "The Signature of All Things" by Elizabeth Gilbert because Gilbert creates such a rich and intricate history of botany and the globalization of it for a fiction piece.

Also from our circulation desk we have science fiction and fantasy recommendations. Mike recommends "Adiamante" by L.E. Modesitt Jr. "Adiamante" is a great non-series hard sci-fi book that ends up being a commentary on the way we approach the world around us.

Tara recommends "Monstrous Regiment" by Terry Pratchett and "The House of the Scorpion" by Nancy Farmer. "Regiment" is, like most of Pratchett's books, a part of his discworld series and involves Polly's decision to join the army even though she has to pretend to be male. And "Scorpion" is set in a world of drug lords and cloning. In it the clone of a wealthy drug lord learns how important his life really is.

Since people might be traveling to distant places this summer, Betty, one of our traveling employees who works at many of our branches, recommends "My Berlin Kitchen" by Luisa Weiss and "Almost French" by Sarah Turnbull. Both are journalistic memoirs about living in Europe and moving from one culture to another, with delightful insights into adapting to new relationships, customs and languages.

Kaylene, who also works at our circulation desk, recommends "Rat Island" by William Stolzenburg. Kaylene describes this book as a fascinating story of a controversial conservation practice: exterminating one species to save another. Even without having read these three titles I know that, if I have a choice, I will encourage my wife to plan a trip to Europe this summer and not to Rat Island.

Even if they have poisoned all of the rats, Europe sounds like more fun.

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